

COMPARATIVE RELIGION

A Short Introduction to the World's Faith Traditions

Base Volume — Foundations for Further Study

A Note to the Reader

This volume is meant as a base: a short, neutral overview of six major world religions, side by side, that can serve as a foundation for deeper, topic-specific studies later — on prayer, pilgrimage, dietary law, scripture, or any other single thread that runs through several traditions at once. Each tradition is described on its own terms first, and compared only afterward. Nothing here is meant to rank one path above another; the goal is orientation, not judgment.

Chapter 1: Why Compare Religions at All

The academic field of comparative religion does not try to decide which tradition is correct. Instead, it asks a quieter set of questions: What problem is this tradition responding to? What counts as sacred within it? How do its practices shape the daily life of its followers? Approached this way, comparison becomes a tool for understanding rather than a contest — a way of noticing both how differently human communities have answered the biggest questions, and how often their answers rhyme.

Chapter 2: Hinduism

Hinduism is less a single organized religion than a family of related traditions that developed on the Indian subcontinent over several thousand years, with no single founder and no single central authority. It includes an enormous range of belief, from strict monotheism to polytheism to philosophical non-dualism, unified loosely by shared texts, festivals, and concepts.

- Sacred texts: the Vedas, Upanishads, Bhagavad Gita, and epics such as the Mahabharata and Ramayana.
- Core ideas: dharma (duty/right action), karma (moral cause and effect), samsara (the cycle of rebirth), and moksha (liberation from that cycle).
- Practice: puja (worship of a deity, often at a home shrine or temple), festivals such as Diwali and Holi, and yoga as a spiritual as well as physical discipline.

Chapter 3: Buddhism

Buddhism began in the 5th or 6th century BCE with Siddhartha Gautama, later known as the Buddha ('the awakened one'), in what is now Nepal and northern India. It shares vocabulary with Hinduism — karma, samsara — but reframes them around a central diagnosis: that suffering arises from craving and attachment, and that a disciplined path can end it.

- Sacred texts: the Tripitaka (Pali Canon), along with later texts specific to Mahayana and Vajrayana schools.
- Core ideas: the Four Noble Truths and the Eightfold Path; the doctrine of anatta (no fixed, permanent self).
- Practice: meditation, mindfulness, ethical precepts (such as non-harm), and, in many schools, monastic life.

Chapter 4: Judaism

Judaism traces its origin to the covenant between God and Abraham described in the Hebrew Bible, and understands itself as both a religion and the identity of a people. It is the oldest of the three Abrahamic faiths and has shaped the theological vocabulary of both Christianity and Islam.

- Sacred texts: the Tanakh (Hebrew Bible), and the Talmud, a vast body of legal and ethical commentary.

- Core ideas: strict monotheism, the covenant with God, and a strong emphasis on law (halakha) as a way of sanctifying everyday life.
- Practice: Sabbath observance from Friday to Saturday evening, kosher dietary law, and prayer three times daily, especially the Amidah.

Chapter 5: Christianity

Christianity emerged from a first-century Jewish movement centered on Jesus of Nazareth, whom his followers proclaimed as the Messiah and the Son of God. It split early from other Jewish groups and, over the following centuries, spread across the Roman world and eventually across the globe, developing major branches — Catholic, Orthodox, and Protestant — with differing structures and practices.

- Sacred text: the Bible, comprising the Old Testament (shared substantially with the Hebrew Bible) and the New Testament.
- Core ideas: the death and resurrection of Jesus as the basis for salvation, and the Trinity — one God in three persons.
- Practice: varies widely by denomination, but commonly includes weekly worship, the sacraments (such as baptism and communion), and personal or liturgical prayer.

Chapter 6: Islam

Islam began in the 7th century CE in Arabia with the Prophet Muhammad, who Muslims believe received revelations later compiled into the Qur'an. It considers itself a continuation and completion of the earlier Abrahamic revelations given to figures such as Abraham, Moses, and Jesus, all honored as prophets.

- Sacred text: the Qur'an, supplemented by the Hadith, records of the Prophet's sayings and actions.
- Core ideas: strict monotheism (tawhid) and submission to God's will (the literal meaning of 'Islam').
- Practice: the Five Pillars — the declaration of faith, five daily prayers (Namaz/Salah), almsgiving, fasting during Ramadan, and pilgrimage to Mecca.

Chapter 7: Sikhism

Sikhism arose in 15th-century Punjab through the teachings of Guru Nanak and nine successor Gurus, in a region where Hindu and Islamic traditions were both present and in active dialogue. It developed its own distinct scripture, community structures, and ethical emphases.

- Sacred text: the Guru Granth Sahib, treated as the living, eternal Guru.
- Core ideas: one formless God, equality of all people regardless of caste or gender, and a life of honest work and service.

- Practice: daily recitation of set prayers (Nitnem), communal worship at the gurdwara, and seva (selfless service), often expressed through the langar, a free community kitchen open to all.

Chapter 8: Side by Side

Tradition	Approx. Origin	Sacred Text(s)	View of God	Central Practice
Hinduism	c. 1500 BCE or earlier	Vedas, Upanishads, Gita	Varies: one, many, or formless	Puja, festivals, yoga
Buddhism	c. 5th–6th century BCE	Tripitaka / Pali Canon	Non-theistic (in most schools)	Meditation, ethical precepts
Judaism	c. 2000–1500 BCE	Tanakh, Talmud	One God (strict monotheism)	Sabbath, dietary law, prayer
Christianity	1st century CE	Bible (Old & New Testament)	One God, in three persons	Worship, sacraments, prayer
Islam	7th century CE	Qur'an, Hadith	One God (strict monotheism)	Five Pillars, including Namaz
Sikhism	15th century CE	Guru Granth Sahib	One formless God	Nitnem, seva, langar

Read across the table, a few patterns stand out. Three of the six traditions here — Judaism, Christianity, and Islam — share a common ancestor in the figure of Abraham and a strict monotheism, even though they disagree sharply on doctrine and prophecy. Hinduism and Buddhism share a South Asian origin and a common technical vocabulary (karma, samsara, dharma), even though Buddhism explicitly rejects the idea of a permanent self that Hindu philosophy generally assumes. Sikhism, arising later and in direct contact with both Hindu and Islamic thought, combines a strict monotheism with an emphasis on social equality that responds directly to the caste concerns of its region and time.

Chapter 9: Threads That Recur

- A sacred text or set of texts treated as authoritative, even when interpreted very differently within the tradition.
- An ethical code that extends beyond ritual into everyday conduct — honesty, charity, non-harm, service to others.
- Set times or rhythms of practice: daily prayer, weekly worship, or seasonal festivals that structure the calendar.
- A concern with what happens beyond ordinary life — rebirth, resurrection, judgment, or liberation — even though the specific answers differ enormously.
- A communal dimension: temple, church, mosque, gurdwara, or sangha, that turns private belief into shared identity and mutual obligation.

Conclusion: A Base, Not a Ceiling

This short survey is deliberately a starting point rather than a finished picture. Each tradition summarized here contains internal diversity — schools of thought, regional variations, and centuries of debate — that a book this size cannot represent fully. Its purpose is to provide enough shared vocabulary and structure that more focused comparisons become possible: prayer across traditions, dietary law across traditions, pilgrimage across traditions, and so on, each building on the foundation laid out here.